



Occasionally, a baby is born with or develops a condition that requires **lifelong support**. It may be caused by a faulty **chromosome or gene**, or may have no known cause. You may have found out in pregnancy that your baby had a problem, or it may become evident only **after the birth**, or in the first months of your baby's life.

Special needs

What is meant by “special needs”?

Special needs refers to any condition that means a child, or an adult, needs extra support to reach their potential. If your baby has special needs, she may need help to maximize her opportunities to develop not just physically, but emotionally, socially, and mentally, too. Some conditions present physical or neurological challenges, others require a special diet, or a particular medication to control the condition. Essentially, special needs is an umbrella term for myriad conditions, from those that affect a baby physically, such as chronic illness or malformations in limbs or organs, to those that affect psychological or mental well-being, such as memory disorders or learning difficulties. Chromosomal conditions such as Down syndrome fall under this umbrella term, too, as do some inherited illnesses, such as cystic fibrosis. This section looks at some of the most common special-needs situations, as well as some more rare conditions that are tested for with the heel prick blood test in your baby's first week of life (see p.250).

Readjusting your outlook

In many cases, babies born with special needs aren't “suffering from” anything, but are living with and often overcoming the challenges of conditions that carve their

and your lives into a different kind of normality.

Understanding your baby's condition, and knowing about its causes, features, symptoms, and prognosis, can help you to come to terms with it so that you can nurture your baby in the most positive and fulfilling ways possible.

Your role

If your baby has a condition that requires ongoing care, it can be easy to feel marginalized against the whirling backdrop of medical care, especially in the early years. However, you lie at the heart of your baby's life, and your understanding of her needs is instructive. While doctors can discuss and treat her physical condition, you know best how to ensure her emotional and social well-being. This means that doctors will look to you to take charge of your baby's care, following their advice so that it works for your family. Never underestimate the importance of your opinion, or be afraid to share it, and never be afraid to ask as many questions as you need to.

As your baby grows and gains an understanding of her situation, talk to her about her treatment or the challenges that she faces in age-appropriate terms. Involve siblings and other family members, too, making sure no subject, appropriately discussed, is off-limits, and having open discussions, which will bring you together.